

Grown-up's Playbook: Argos and the Lost Keepsake

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Argos and the Lost Keepsake: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle, kindly tale: there is no fight in it at all, only a lost treasure, a sad friend, and a faithful dog to help you put things right.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Ship Camp.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Cleverness** (a clever plan), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Loyalty** (standing by a friend). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: any seashell for the Conch Horn, a small cake or token for the Basket of Honey and Figs, and a ball of string for Penelope's Thread. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Cleverness and Loyalty together, say, or Courage and Cleverness).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. On these shores, no hero stands alone, and that is the whole heart of this tale.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line

that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Odysseus the Clever gives you one free hint.
2	You find your second wind, and take back one energy star.
3	A fair wind off the sea, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Argos the Faithful Hound trots up and wags his tail. All is well.
5	A basket of figs for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A warm sea breeze, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

There is no foe in this story and no fight to win. The challenge is simply to keep faith with a friend: to follow Argos, read the clues, remember carefully, and not give up until the lost keepsake is found and carried home. Let the reunion land, the friend overjoyed, Argos praised, Thetis the Sea-Mother smiling on the calm sea; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three stops and their solutions.

Argos and the Lost Keepsake: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward cleverness and loyalty over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: Following Argos (Easy)

The challenge. Argos has the scent, but the players must read the tracks and clues along the shore to choose which way their friend walked. Some marks lead onward; some lead nowhere.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Observation and Loyalty. Have the children look closely with Argos and sort the clues: the footprints that carry on in one clear direction, the dropped fig and the resting scuff that sit along that same line, against any stray marks that double back or peter out. Following the clues that agree with one another, and trusting Argos when he barks happily, sends them the right way. Any child who slows down, looks carefully, and stays on the trail has solved it.

Fallback. If they are unsure, let Argos take a few steps the right way and look back, or let them spend an energy star to "look again" and notice that the deep, onward footprints all point the same way. Sticking close to the dog and not giving up always finds the trail; this stop is meant to feel like an easy, happy start.

Stop 2: The Tide Pools (Normal)

The challenge. The trail leads in among three sunlit tide pools, and the players must work out which pool their friend rested beside, where a thread slipped from his cloak.

The worked example. Read the scene so the three pools are clear. Beside **pool one** lies a white shell. Beside **pool two** lies a striped shell. Beside **pool three** lies a smooth grey pebble. Argos gives two clues to hold in mind at once: the scent **passed a striped shell** (so not the white-shell pool), and the scent **did not stop where the pebble was** (so not the pebble pool). Cross off pool one and pool three, and only **pool two**, the striped-shell pool with no pebble, is left. That is where the dropped thread is found, pointing the way on.

Intended solution. This is a Memory, Logic and Observation moment. The clever move is to remember both of Argos's clues and use them to rule pools out one at a time until a single pool remains. Counting on fingers, pointing at each pool in turn, or laying a token by each one as they reason are all good.

Fallback. If the children lose the thread of it, simplify to one clue at a time: "Argos says not the white shell, so which pools are left?" then "Argos says not the pebble, so which one is it?" Or let them spend an energy star while Argos sniffs straight to the right pool. Reaching pool two by any route counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Far Dune (Normal)

The challenge. The keepsake has fallen near a lonely dune and the wind has half buried it in the sand. Argos finds the spot; the players must dig it out gently and reunite their friend with it.

Intended solution. This is an Observation and Loyalty moment. The clever, kind move is to watch where Argos points his nose, kneel at that exact spot, and dig carefully together, brushing the sand away a little at a time and watching for a corner of olive wood rather than scrabbling and scattering it. When they do, the carved token comes up warm and whole, and Argos frees the last of it with one gentle paw. Patience and care, not force, win the day.

Fallback. If a child digs in the wrong place or grows frustrated, have Argos pad over, sniff once, and start the digging himself right where it should be, so they can join in. Spending an energy star to "look closer" also reveals the glint of wood. The keepsake is always found; the only question is how tenderly.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the keepsake is carried home, Lykos is overjoyed and hugs both the token and Argos, Odysseus the Clever praises the heroes for leaving no one behind, and **Thetis the Sea-Mother** smiles on the calm sea so the ships may sail home with every friend and treasure safe aboard. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being clever, brave, and loyal.

Wits and Wonder

Grown-up's Playbook

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.